CarHandled

THE CAR BUYING TOOLKIT

The shortest path to a clean *Out the Door*.

2026 EDITION

01	Before You Shop
02	The Email Game
03	Reading the Numbers
04	Inside the Store
05	At the Dealership
06	The Finance Office
✦	First Time Buyer Extras

"I signed at 18% APR because I didn't know better. Now I'm on your side."

ALI · FOUNDER · 500+ DEALS NEGOTIATED

A NOTE FROM THE FOUNDER

“I walked into a finance office confused and walked out with a payment I didn’t understand.”

That was my first car.



18% APR. A new country. I didn’t know what OTD meant. I didn’t know the add-ons were optional. I didn’t know I could walk away.

Years later I worked inside dealerships, sold hundreds of cars, and learned the whole playbook from the other side of the desk. I saw the same confusion on buyers every single day.

CarHandled exists because nobody should sign a deal they don’t understand. This toolkit is everything I wish I’d had: plain language, copy and paste scripts, and real numbers.

Read it once before you shop. Use it at every step. You’ll walk out with a deal you actually understand.

Ali

FOUNDER, CARHANDLED · 500+ DEALS NEGOTIATED

Clean numbers	Email first	Simple
or no deal	pressure last	beats clever

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

CONTENTS

What's inside

Read it front to back once. After that, jump to the step you're on.

01 **Before You Shop** 03
Terms · Checklist · Budget · Credit · Rebates

02 **The Email Game** 09
OTD scripts · All 10 steps · The $300 rule

03 **Reading the Numbers** 14
OTD breakdowns · Interest · Lease math

04 **Inside the Store** NEW 18
Four square · Manager trips · How they're paid · Timing

05 **At the Dealership** 24
Common traps · Delivery day checklist

06 **The Finance Office** 27
Every add-on · Keep or skip · What to say

✦ **First Time Buyer Extras** 30
Insurance · Questions · Red flags · Used cars · Mindset

Email first. Walk in to sign, not to be sold.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

01

CHAPTER 01

Before You Shop

Terms · Checklist · Budget · Credit · Rebates

Most of the money is saved before you ever talk to a dealer.

A pre-approval, a shortlist and a budget ceiling. That's the whole job of this chapter, and it's worth $1,000 or more on its own.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

THE VOCABULARY

Terms in plain English

Twelve words that run every deal. Learn them once.

OTD	Out the door total: price + fees + tax + DMV. The only number that matters.
MSRP	Manufacturer's sticker price. Your negotiated selling price starts here.
Doc fee	Dealer paperwork charge, usually $200–$900. Some states cap it. Offset it through price.
Buyer's order	Manager signed document with the OTD and VIN. Don't schedule pickup without it.
Pre-approval	The rate your bank or credit union offers you. The dealer has to beat it to earn your loan.
Captive lender	The brand's own finance arm (Toyota Financial, Ford Credit). Source of special rates.
Rebate	Cash from the manufacturer. Separate from, and stackable with, your price negotiation.
Money factor	A lease's interest rate. Multiply by 2,400 for the approximate APR.
Residual	The car's estimated value at lease end, as a % of MSRP. Higher means a lower payment.
GAP	Covers the difference if the car is totaled and you owe more than it's worth.
VSC	Vehicle service contract, a.k.a. extended warranty. Optional, and often cheaper later.
CPO	Certified Pre-Owned. A manufacturer inspected used car with warranty coverage.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

THE PLAN

First time buyer checklist

Do these in order. Don’t skip steps 1 through 4.

1. **Pick 2–3 trims you’d buy today**
   Decide before you go. Dealers use indecision to push upgrades.
2. **Get a bank or credit union pre-approval**
   Rate, months and monthly limit. Screenshot it and bring it.
3. **Get an insurance quote for that exact car**
   Know the real monthly cost before you commit. Sport trims cost more to insure.
4. **Test drive, then go home**
   Never negotiate the same day you drive. Emotion is expensive.
5. **Email 5–8 dealers for an OTD**
   Include ZIP, stock #, VIN and plate type (new or transfer). No phone calls.
6. **Collect 3+ written OTD replies**
   You need competition. One quote is not a negotiation.
7. **Pick your target OTD and send one counter**
   One number. Short message. No long explanations.
8. **Get a manager signed buyer’s order**
   OTD and VIN in writing. Only then schedule pickup.
9. **Arrive with every document**
   License, insurance card, payment method. Print the delivery checklist on page 26.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

WORKSHEET

Needs & budget

Fill this in before you open a single listing.

YOUR MONEY GUARDRAIL

MAX OTD $ _____

OR MAX MONTHLY $ _____

FOR MONTHS _____

Aim for 60 months or less. Only go 72+ if the rate is very low and you'll keep the car 6+ years.

Must haves

- ☐ AWD / 4WD
- ☐ Third row
- ☐ Towing
- ☐ EV / Hybrid
- ☐ IIHS safety rating
- ☐ CarPlay / Android Auto
- ☐ Cargo space
- ☐ _____

Deal breakers

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Trim shortlist (2–3 you'd buy today)

YEAR / MAKE / MODEL / TRIM	MSRP EST.	NOTES

Rules of thumb

- **Never reveal your max monthly.** It lets them build the deal around your number instead of the price.
- **Keep it to 60 months or less.** Each extra 12 months adds $1,000+ in interest on a typical loan.
- **Get pre-approved first.** The dealer then has to beat your rate to earn the loan.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

CREDIT

What your score costs you

Your tier sets your rate range. Higher tier, lower rate, thousands saved.

TIER 1	750+	Excellent. Best available rates, including manufacturer specials.
TIER 2	700–749	Good. Near best rates, a small premium over Tier 1.
TIER 3	660–699	Fair. Noticeably higher rates. Raising your score first pays.
TIER 4	620–659	Subprime. Consider 3–6 months of score repair before shopping.
TIER 5	<620	Deep subprime. Much higher rates. A co-signer may help.

Tier 3 to Tier 2 on a $30,000, 60 month loan can save roughly $40–$70 a month and $2,500–$4,000 in total interest. One credit card paydown can move you a full tier.

Raise your score before you buy

- Pay credit card balances below 30% of the limit. It’s the fastest single lever.
- Don’t open new cards in the 3 months before you apply for a car loan.
- Rate shop in a tight window. Multiple auto loan inquiries within 14 days count as one.
- Pull your free reports at annualcreditreport.com and dispute any errors. They’re more common than you’d think.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

FREE MONEY

Rebates & incentives

Manufacturer offers that cut your real cost on top of negotiation.

Cash rebate

A fixed amount off from the manufacturer, usually usable as a down payment. It's separate from the dealer negotiation, so you negotiate the price *and* get the rebate. $2,500 back on a $32,000 car is a $29,500 starting point.

Special APR (0%–3.9%)

A subsidized rate through the brand's captive lender. You usually need Tier 1 or 2 credit. **The catch:** it's usually the rebate *or* the special rate, rarely both. Run the math on each.

Loyalty rebate

Typically $500–$1,500 if you own or lease the same brand now, sometimes even if someone in your household does. Usually stacks.

ASK "Is there a loyalty rebate for current [brand] owners?"

Conquest rebate

For buyers switching from a competitor. Often $500–$2,000 on top of other offers.

ASK "Is there a conquest offer for switching from [your brand]?"

Military, first responder, recent grad

Usually $500–$1,000, verified, and almost always stackable. These are manufacturer programs, so the dealer can't take them away.

Find current offers: manufacturer website → Offers → enter your ZIP. They change monthly, so check right before you email dealers.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

02

CHAPTER 02

The Email Game

OTD scripts · All 10 steps · The $300 rule

Never negotiate on the phone. Everything in writing.

Walk in to sign, not to be sold.

5–8	3+	$300
Dealers to email	Written OTDs needed	Fair deal rule

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

STEPS 1–3

Get the number

Copy, fill in the brackets, send. Don't call.

INITIAL EMAIL

1 Ask for the OTD

> Subject: Stock #[___] OTD request, ready to deposit
>
> Hi [Name], I'm deciding on a [model/trim] this week. For Stock # [___] / VIN [___], please email the full OTD for [ZIP], [new/transfer] plate, no trade.
>
> I'm pre-approved at [X]% for [Y] months. Beat it and I'll finance with you.
>
> Please include: vehicle price · dealer fees and add-ons · tax · tag/DMV · OTD total. If the number works, I'll place a deposit and schedule pickup [day/time].
>
> Thanks, [Your name]

THE OTD IS GOOD

2 Say yes

> That works. Please email a manager signed buyer's order with the OTD and VIN. I'll place a refundable deposit and confirm pickup.

CLOSE, BUT FEES ARE HIGH

3 Counter the add-ons

> Please remove or offset the add-ons and bring the OTD to $[target]. If you can, I'll deposit and schedule pickup today.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

STEP 4

The step that moves the number

Use it when the OTD is simply too high.

OTD TOO HIGH

4 The hard counter

> Thanks for the breakdown. That OTD is above two written quotes I already have for the same trim.
>
> My target is $[target] OTD on Stock #[___] / VIN [___], no add-ons, [ZIP], [new/transfer] plate.
>
> Meet it and I'll place a refundable deposit today and take delivery [day/time]. If you can't, no hard feelings, I'll go with the other store.

Why this one matters

Steps 1 to 3 get you a number. This is the step that moves it. Most buyers either accept the first OTD or go quiet, and both read as "not a real buyer." One firm number, one deadline, one named alternative. No arguing line items, no explaining yourself.

Send one counter. Not three. A second counter tells them the first one wasn't real.

If they counter your counter

Apply the $300 Fair Deal Rule on page 13. Inside $300, take it and ask for the signed buyer's order. Outside $300, give the other store a chance to match.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

STEPS 5–9

Keep it in writing

Responses for the moves dealers make next.

THEY WON'T EMAIL NUMBERS

5 Hold the line

> I decide from a written breakdown. Email the line items and OTD for [ZIP] and [plate] and I'll deposit. Otherwise I'll go elsewhere.

AFTER A SHORT CALL

6 Email recap

> Thanks for the call. I'm deciding this week on Stock #[___]. Please email the breakdown we discussed. If it works, I'll place a refundable deposit.

BEFORE YOU PAY ANYTHING

7 Protect your deposit

> The deposit is refundable until I sign a manager signed buyer's order with the agreed OTD and VIN. Any change to the terms means a full refund. Hold window: [date/time].

DEAL AGREED

8 Request the buyer's order

> Please email the manager signed buyer's order with the OTD, the VIN, and anything that was promised verbally.

DAY BEFORE

9 Confirm pickup

> I'll arrive [day/time] with my license, insurance and payment. Please have the car ready and the paperwork printed.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

STEP 10 + THE RULE

Walk away, or close it

You'll use one of these on every deal.

NO WRITTEN NUMBERS

10 **Walk away**

> I need a written breakdown to move forward, so I'll go with another store. Thanks for your time.

THE $300 FAIR DEAL RULE

Get at least 3 written OTDs before you decide anything.

A Deal #1 is within **$300** of deal #2? Take #1 and ask for the signed buyer's order right away.

B Gap bigger than $300? Tell dealer #2: *"Match deal #1's OTD and I'll deposit right now."*

C A tie? Whoever emails the manager signed buyer's order first gets your business.

Why it works

- Competition between dealers is your strongest tool. One quote is not a negotiation.
- The $300 line stops you from burning a week over money that doesn't matter.
- Asking for the buyer's order immediately locks the deal before anything can change.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

03

CHAPTER 03

Reading the Numbers

OTD breakdowns · Interest · Lease math

"$4,081 difference on the same car. That's the junk fee gap."

This chapter shows you how to spot it, line by line.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

SIDE BY SIDE

Clean deal vs junk deal

Same car. Same MSRP. 8.5% sales tax in both.

✓ CLEAN DEAL

Vehicle price	$25,800
Doc fee	$399 NORMAL
Add-ons	$0 TARGET
Sales tax	$2,227
DMV / tag	$415
OTD total	**$28,841**

One doc fee. No junk. Tax and DMV look right. Easy to compare.

× JUNK FEE DEAL

Vehicle price	$25,800
“Pro pack” add-on	$1,995 JUNK
Doc fee	$899 HIGH
Nitrogen	$199 JUNK
VIN etch	$399 JUNK
Window tint	$499 ASK TO REMOVE
Sales tax	$2,532 TAXED ON JUNK
DMV / tag	$599 HIGH
OTD total	**$32,922**

Ask them to remove the add-ons or offset them in the price. If they won’t move, walk.

Difference on the same car **$4,081**

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

INTEREST

What the term really costs

A $25,000 loan. Monthly payment, with total interest underneath.

APR	48 MO	60 MO	72 MO
4%	$564 $2,095	$460 $2,625	$391 $3,161
6%	$587 $3,182	$483 $3,999	$414 $4,831
8%	$610 $4,296	$507 $5,415	$438 $6,560
10%	$634 $5,435	$531 $6,871	$463 $8,347
12%	$658 $6,601	$556 $8,367	$489 $10,190

Example rates only. Your actual rate depends on your credit tier.

Stretching the term always costs more. At 8%, going from 60 to 72 months saves $69 a month and costs $1,145 more in interest. Lower rate, shorter term and more down is the winning combination.

Pre-approval, your best weapon

- Apply at your bank or credit union before you contact any dealer.
- Bring the rate and term in writing. The dealer has to beat it to get your financing.
- Multiple auto loan inquiries within 14 days count as one hard pull.
- Dealer insists you finance with them? Ask about a prepayment penalty. If there isn't one, take their deal and refinance later.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

LEASING

Should you lease?

Leasing isn't buying. Know which one fits before you walk in.

LEASE IF

- You drive under 12,000–15,000 miles a year
- You want a new car every 2–3 years
- The monthly matters more than ownership
- The brand is offering a very low money factor
- You don't want to worry about resale

BUY IF

- You drive more than 15,000 miles a year
- You plan to keep the car long term
- You want to own it and stop paying eventually
- You like to modify your cars
- You want to be free to sell anytime

Lease math in plain English

Money factor	The lease interest rate. MF × 2,400 ≈ APR. Ask for the buy rate so it isn't marked up.
Residual %	Value at lease end as a % of MSRP. Set by the lender, not negotiable. Higher means a lower payment.
Cap cost	The selling price inside a lease. This **is** negotiable. Lower cap cost, lower payment.
MF markup	Dealers can raise the money factor for profit. Ask: "Are you using the buy rate?"

Negotiate the cap cost exactly like a purchase price.

A lower selling price is a lower monthly payment. Don't skip this step.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com



CHAPTER 04 · NEW IN 2026

Inside the Store

Four square · Manager trips · How they're paid · Timing

You already know what to say. This chapter is why it works.

None of this is a secret to them. It's just never explained to you. Every tactic here is standard practice, and every one of them has a counter.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

THE WORKSHEET

The four square

The sheet that gets slid across the desk.

TRADE VALUE Inflated to feel generous	**PURCHASE PRICE** Where the real money hides
DOWN PAYMENT Raised to fix the payment	**MONTHLY PAYMENT** The only box you're shown

What it's actually doing

Four numbers move at once. They give in one box and take it back in another. A better trade number gets paid for in the price box, a lower payment gets paid for with a longer term. Nothing is ever pinned down, so nothing can be compared. Written quotes from other stores are the antidote, because they pin all four.

SAY "I don't work from a four square. Email me an itemized OTD."

Why they ask your monthly payment first

A payment target is the most useful thing you can hand them. With it they can hit your number by adjusting term, rate, down payment and add-ons, while the selling price stays wherever they like. You get the payment you asked for and never learn what you paid for the car.

SAY "I'm not discussing monthly until we've agreed on the OTD."

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

THE WAIT

“Let me talk to my manager”

The trip is real. How long it takes is a tool.

What’s happening back there

Most salespeople don’t set prices. A desk manager does, so the trip is genuine. But the clock is working too. The longer you sit, the more time you’ve invested, and the more expensive walking out feels. It’s the most reliable pressure in the building, and it costs them nothing.

Bring something to read. Look unbothered. Time is only leverage if it isn’t yours.

When they come back, don’t fill the silence

The return is usually a number and a pause. The pause is for you to fill, and buyers fill it by negotiating against themselves: raising their own offer, explaining their budget, apologizing. Let it sit. Answer the number, nothing else.

SAY Nothing. Then: “Can you put that in writing?”

How the salesperson is paid

Commission on front end gross (profit on the car), often a share of back end gross (finance and products), and volume bonuses at unit targets. A hard negotiated car often pays a flat “mini” commission. That cuts your way more than you’d think: someone one car short of a bonus will take a thin deal a manager would normally wave off.

That’s why a decisive, easy, ready to sign buyer gets a better number.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

THE BACK OFFICE

The finance office, from inside

Why it's a separate room and a separate negotiation.

How the F&I manager is paid

Mostly on back end gross: the products sold and the markup earned on your interest rate. They're also measured on penetration, the share of customers who leave with a service contract, GAP and the rest. That's why the pitch continues after you say no, and why you'll hear "almost everyone takes this one" in every store in the country.

SAY **"I'm declining all products today. Please print it with financing only."**

The markup on your rate

When the dealer arranges your loan, the lender approves you at a buy rate. Your contract rate can be higher, and the difference is dealer profit. It's legal, it's in the paperwork, and it's completely avoidable. A pre-approval in hand turns it into a competition they have to win.

SAY **"What's the buy rate? My credit union is at [X]%."**

Why timing changes the number

Manufacturers pay dealers bonuses on volume targets, and dealers pay interest on every car sitting on the lot, every day. A store one car short of a target on the 30th values that car differently than on the 3rd. Same with a car that's been sitting for ninety days.

ASK **"Which units in this trim have been in stock the longest?"**

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

YOUR EMAIL

Your email, from their side

What happens to the message you send in Chapter 02.

Who reads it

Internet leads go to a BDC or internet department, not the person on the showroom floor. They're measured on response time and appointments set, not on price. Their job is to turn your email into a visit, which is why the first reply so often answers a question you didn't ask.

Why a vague email gets a template

"What's your best price on a Highlander?" has no stock number, no timeline and no financing. It reads as early stage, so it gets a canned reply and a push to call. An email with the VIN, ZIP, plate type, a pre-approval and a buying window reads as someone who'll sign this week, and it gets routed to someone who can actually quote a number.

Every line of the Chapter 02 script is there to trigger that routing.

Why they'd rather call you

On the phone there's no record, tone does the work, and the goal becomes getting you into the building. In writing the numbers stay put and can be shown to a competitor. Keeping it in email isn't rude. It's the entire advantage.

SAY "Happy to talk, but I decide from a written breakdown."

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

YOUR SIDE OF THE TABLE

Where your leverage is

Five things they can’t take from you.

1 **Written quotes from other stores**
The only thing that moves a floor. One quote is a conversation. Three is a market.

2 **Willingness to walk**
Not a bluff, a plan. There’s another car, and it’s usually within fifty miles.

3 **A deposit is not a contract**
Until you sign the purchase agreement, you can leave. Nobody in the building will remind you.

4 **Timing**
End of month, end of quarter, and any car that’s been sitting. All of it is their pressure, not yours.

5 **Being easy to say yes to**
Specific, decisive, financing sorted, ready to sign. The cheapest customer to sell gets the best number.

None of this makes them the enemy.

It’s a business with a playbook. Now you’ve read it too, and you can be the buyer they’re glad walked in.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

05

CHAPTER 05

At the Dealership

Common traps · Delivery day checklist

You have the right to walk at any point.

A signed deposit is not a signed purchase contract.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

ON THE FLOOR

Common traps, and what to say

You'll hear most of these. Have the answer ready.

THEY SAY	YOU SAY
You have to finance with us.	Only if there's no prepayment penalty. I can refinance later.
This price is today only.	If it's real today, it's real tomorrow. Email me the OTD.
Look at this great monthly payment!	Let's confirm the OTD and the term first. I'll do the math.
The add-ons are already on the car.	Remove them or take the cost off the price, or I'll find another car.
We can't email OTD numbers.	Send it pre-tax and I'll confirm the tax. I still need it in writing.
Let me talk to my manager.	Take your time. I have quotes from two other dealers.
We can roll your negative equity in.	Show me the OTD and the payoff as separate lines, not blended.
You qualify for 0% with our financing.	Is there a prepayment penalty? No? Great, I'll take the 0%.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

PRINT THIS

Delivery day checklist

Check every item before you sign anything.

INSPECT THE CAR FIRST

- ☐ Exterior: dents, scratches, paint
- ☐ All 4 tires: no damage, even tread
- ☐ Windows, sunroof and locks work
- ☐ Both keys present, fuel level noted
- ☐ Every feature demoed and working

BEFORE YOU SIGN

- ☐ VIN on the paperwork matches the car
- ☐ OTD on the contract matches your email
- ☐ No new fees or add-ons
- ☐ Rate matches or beats your pre-approval
- ☐ Term matches exactly what you agreed

IN THE FINANCE OFFICE

- ☐ Read every line, not just signature pages
- ☐ Add-ons are only what you agreed to
- ☐ Get copies of everything you sign
- ☐ Never sign a blank “we owe” form
- ☐ Any warranty price matches the quote

BRING WITH YOU

- ☐ Driver’s license (every buyer)
- ☐ Insurance card covering the new car
- ☐ Pre-approval letter or lender contact
- ☐ Payment: cashier’s or personal check
- ☐ 10 day payoff letter if trading in

If anything changed, stop. Ask for the manager. You can leave before signing. A deposit is not a contract.

IF SOMETHING’S WRONG AT PICKUP, SAY THIS

“I see a difference between what we agreed in writing and this contract. I’m not comfortable signing until it’s corrected. Can we get the manager to review it with us?”

Then wait. Silence is your friend. Don’t fill it.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

06

CHAPTER 06

The Finance Office

Every add-on · Keep or skip · What to say

First rule: everything in this room is optional.

Sign only what you understand. You can always say no. The finance manager is paid to sell too.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

ADD-ONS, PART 1

Keep or skip

The usual menu, in the order you'll see it.

GAP insurance SOMETIMES

Covers the difference if the car is totaled and you owe more than it's worth.

BUY IF less than 20% down, or financing 72+ months. **SKIP IF** your insurer offers it cheaper, which it usually does.

SAY "What's the price? I'll compare it with my insurance company."

Extended warranty (VSC) SOMETIMES

Covers repairs after the factory warranty ends.

BUY IF you'll keep the car past the warranty and the model has reliability concerns. **SKIP IF** you'll sell within 5 years. You can usually buy it later.

SAY "Can I buy this closer to when my factory warranty expires?"

Prepaid maintenance SOMETIMES

Prepays oil changes and scheduled service at dealer prices.

BUY IF it's cheaper than paying as you go and refundable pro rata. **SKIP IF** you use an independent shop or the terms are unclear.

SAY "Is this fully refundable pro rata if I sell or total the car?"

Tire & wheel protection SOMETIMES

Covers flat tires and wheel damage from road hazards.

BUY IF you have low profile tires or drive rough roads. **SKIP IF** standard tires and decent roads. One claim should pay for it.

SAY "Show me the deductible and the claim process in writing."

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

ADD-ONS, PART 2

Just say no

These two have no good version at dealer prices.

Paint, fabric & ceramic packages SKIP

Paint sealant, fabric protection and ceramic coating, often marked up 400% to 600%. Better products are available later for a fraction of the cost.

SAY "No thank you." Nothing more. Don't engage further.

VIN etch, nitrogen, GPS tracking SKIP

VIN etching runs $200–$400 at the dealer and about $30 as a kit at an auto parts store. Air is already 78% nitrogen.

SAY "Remove it, or take the full cost off the selling price."

Quick reference

GAP	SOMETIMES
Extended warranty	SOMETIMES
Prepaid maintenance	SOMETIMES
Tire & wheel	SOMETIMES
Paint / fabric / ceramic	SKIP
VIN etch / nitrogen / GPS	SKIP

"Take your time. I want to review these at home."

You can always say no. Nothing in the finance office is required.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

BONUS CHAPTER

First Time Buyer Extras

Insurance · Questions · Red flags · Used cars · Mindset

- You don’t have to buy on your first visit.
- Never reveal your max monthly budget.
- The finance office is a second negotiation.
- Most states require insurance before you take delivery. Have it ready.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

INSURANCE 101

Before you buy

Get a quote before you fall for a car. The premium changes everything.

Liability REQUIRED
Required by law in every state. Covers damage you cause to other people and their property.

Collision GET IT
Covers your car in a crash. Usually required if you finance.

Comprehensive GET IT
Theft, weather, fire, animals, falling objects. Usually cheap and worth it.

GAP IF FINANCED
Covers the loan gap if the car is totaled. Usually cheaper from your insurer than the dealer.

Uninsured motorist RECOMMENDED
Covers you if you're hit by a driver with no insurance. More common than you'd think.

Rental reimbursement OPTIONAL
Pays for a rental while your car is repaired after a covered claim. Low cost.

Five things that set your premium

- **Credit score.** Most states let insurers use it.
- **Trim.** Sport and performance trims cost much more to insure.
- **ZIP code.** Cities run higher than suburbs and rural areas.
- **Deductible.** Higher lowers the premium but costs more when you claim.
- **Mileage.** Less driving, less risk. Give an honest estimate.

> **Get at least 3 quotes.** Rates vary a lot between insurers. Fifteen minutes can save $400+ a year.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

ASK THESE

Questions for every stage

Copy them into your notes app.

RESEARCHING ONLINE

- What's the OTD for my ZIP with a new plate and no trade?
- Which dealer fees are included, and can any be removed or offset?
- Is this exact car in stock, or does it need to be ordered or transferred?

BY EMAIL OR PHONE

- Can you email a full breakdown: price, fees, tax, DMV and OTD total?
- What's the doc fee? Are any add-ons already installed?
- What's the earliest pickup if I place a refundable deposit today?

IN THE FINANCE OFFICE

- What exactly does this product cover, and what does it exclude?
- Is there a prepayment penalty on this loan?
- Can I decline this now, or take it home to review?

Red flags. Walk away if you see these.

- No written OTD after several polite requests.
- The payment or rate changed from what you agreed by email.
- New add-ons appeared on the contract that were never discussed.
- Pressure to decide in the next 10 or 15 minutes.
- The VIN on the contract doesn't match the car you inspected.
- "The manager already approved it," but nobody will show you in writing.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

BUYING USED

Four rules that protect you

Chapters 02 through 05 still apply. These four are unique to used cars.

1 **Always get a pre-purchase inspection**

An independent mechanic, not the seller's shop, checks the car for about $100–$200. It's the highest return step of any used purchase and can uncover thousands in deferred repairs. A seller who refuses a PPI is your answer. Walk.

2 **Run a vehicle history report**

Carfax or AutoCheck. Look for accidents, number of owners, title brands (salvage, rebuilt, flood), odometer flags and service records. A clean report doesn't guarantee a clean car, but a dirty one is a hard stop.

3 **Know CPO vs as-is vs private party**

CPO: manufacturer warranty and inspection, costs more but covered. **As-is dealer:** no warranty, negotiate harder, PPI is mandatory. **Private party:** often cheapest. Confirm the title is clean and in the seller's name before anything else.

4 **Price it from the market, not MSRP**

Used prices are set by comparable sales, not a sticker. Check at least two market sources before you negotiate.

The OTD email works on used cars too.

Just swap MSRP for your market comparables.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

MINDSET

Think like a prepared buyer

Eight ideas that do more than any script.

You don't have to buy on your first visit

Dealers manufacture urgency. The car will almost always be there tomorrow. Patience is leverage.

Never reveal your max monthly

It lets them hit your number while hiding the real OTD.

Email when the store is quiet

Internet managers often answer faster and more directly in the evening or early morning, when the floor isn't busy.

The finance office is a second negotiation

Everything they offer is optional. Nothing is "standard" unless you agree to it.

Your first car doesn't have to be perfect

A reliable, affordable car you negotiated well beats a dream car you overpaid for.

If the numbers changed, walk

Sometimes the best deal you'll ever make is the one you walked away from.

A deposit is not a purchase

Until you sign the purchase contract, you can leave. Don't let anyone tell you otherwise.

Get everything in writing, every time

If it was only said out loud, it doesn't count.

© 2026 CarHandled · carhandled.com

You're ready.

Most buyers walk in hoping for the best. You're walking in with a system.

I sat on both sides of that desk.
I know what the manager says when you leave the room.
I know which add-ons are margin and which might matter.
And now, so do you.

ALI · FOUNDER, CARHANDLED

THREE THINGS TO DO NOW

1. Send the OTD email to 5–8 dealers this week.
2. Share this with a friend who's buying a car.
3. Follow @carhandled on Instagram.

WANT A SECOND SET OF EYES?

Deal Review · $129
Send me your quotes. I'll tell you what's wrong and what to say back.

Concierge · $1,000
Flat fee, by application. I source, negotiate and coordinate delivery.

30 DAY REFUND GUARANTEE · FREE UPDATES FOR LIFE

info@carhandled.com · carhandled.com · @carhandled

© 2026 CarHandled · For personal use only · Not for redistribution